DSEH004 Performance Management and Employee Engagement

Week 6 | Lecture 2 | Unit I to Unit II bridge

Reading Pulse Data Honestly

Driver analysis, measurement traps and the difference between a dashboard and a diagnosis

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Commit before theory

A department's engagement score rises from 3.1 to 3.6 after a new manager joins. What can you safely conclude?

A

The new manager caused the rise

B

Engagement improved; the cause is not yet known

C

Nothing until we check who responded and whether the items meant the same

D

The rise is too small to matter

What a pulse survey is actually measuring

1 A construct

Engagement as vigor, dedication and absorption (Schaufeli et al., 2002), not general happiness

2 Through items

Each item is an imperfect indicator; scores carry measurement error

3 From respondents

Only people who chose to answer, at one time, in one mood

Every pulse number is a construct, filtered through items, filtered through who responded

Driver analysis: from scores to priorities

Outcome

Choose the outcome, such as engagement or intent to stay

Candidate drivers

Items or indices that theory says should matter

Relative importance

Estimate each driver's share of explained variance

Priority

Combine importance with current score and feasibility

Johnson and LeBreton (2004): when drivers are correlated, raw regression weights misstate importance; use relative importance indices

The driver priority grid

Importance (high at top)

Fix first

High importance, low score: the biggest lever for improvement

Protect

High importance, high score: keep investing; do not take for granted

Watch

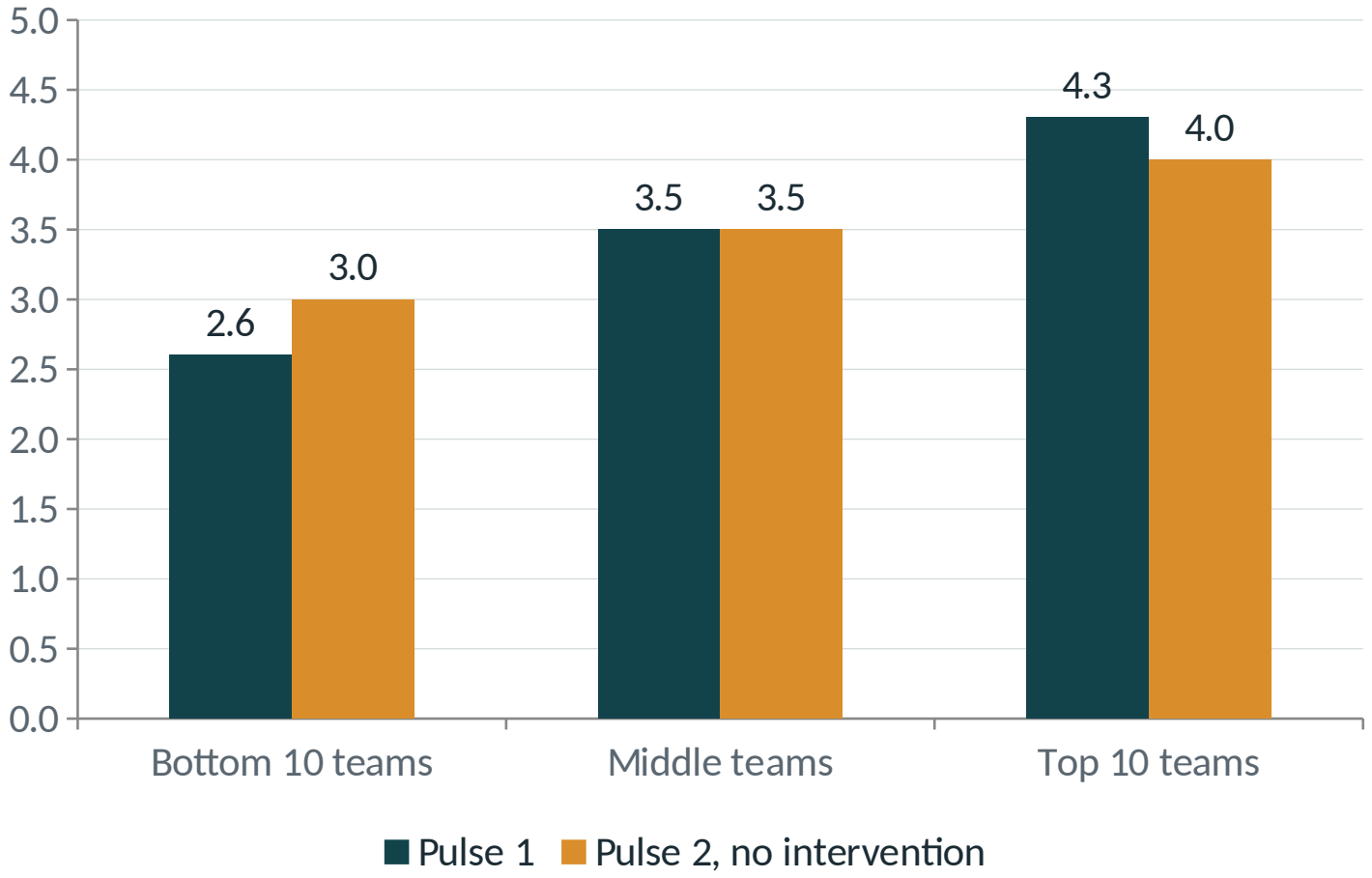
Low importance, low score: monitor; acting here moves little

Do not overinvest

Low importance, high score: already fine, little return

Current score (low to high)

Regression to the mean: the bottom always rises



Illustrative numbers built for teaching, not real data

Teams selected because they scored extreme on one pulse will drift toward the average on the next, even if nothing changed.

An intervention aimed only at the bottom teams will look successful by default.

Remedy: compare with a similar group that did not receive the intervention (Barnett et al., 2005).

Five errors that make a dashboard lie

Error	What goes wrong	Check to run
Nonresponse bias	Unhappy staff skip the survey, so the score flatters	Compare response rates by unit (Rogelberg and Stanton, 2007)
Common method bias	Driver and outcome share one survey, inflating links	Add a second source, such as exits (Podsakoff et al., 2003)
Ecological fallacy	A team-level link is read as true for each person	Keep the level of analysis consistent (Robinson, 1950)
Non-equivalence	Groups read items differently, so gaps are artifacts	Test invariance first (Vandenberg and Lance, 2000)
Campbell's law	Once a target, the score gets managed	Keep scores out of appraisals (Campbell, 1979)

Dashboard theater versus diagnosis

Dashboard theater

- Many colors, few decisions
- Scores shown without response rates or error
- Year-on-year change read as cause
- Action plans written for every item

vs

Honest diagnosis

- Two or three priorities, each tied to a decision
- Response rates and comparison groups shown
- Causes tested with a second data source
- Some items deliberately left alone

Survey fatigue is mostly about action

1 Too frequent

Short cycles without visible change train people to stop answering honestly

2 No feedback loop

If results never return to teams, the survey reads as surveillance

3 Close the loop

Share results, name what will and will not change, report back next cycle

Low response is often a verdict on past action, not on the questionnaire

A bank branch that jumped

Teaching case (Course framing)

A private bank runs a quarterly pulse. Branch 14 had the lowest score in Q1 and received an intensive manager coaching program. In Q2 its score rose by 0.5 points and response rate fell from 82 percent to 55 percent. The regional head wants to roll the program out to all 120 branches.

Work it through

1. List three reasons the rise might not be caused by coaching
2. What comparison group would you ask for?
3. What does the drop in response rate suggest?
4. Write the one-line recommendation you would give the regional head

Common confusions to avoid

A tempting reading	A better reading
A higher score means people are more engaged	Only if the same kind of people answered and read the items the same way
The strongest regression coefficient is the top driver	With correlated drivers, use relative importance, not raw weights
More frequent surveys give better data	Frequency without action lowers honesty and response

Exam-style question

An engagement report shows that teams receiving a new recognition program improved more than other teams. Critically evaluate what the report can and cannot show, and design a better evaluation. (20 marks)

What a strong answer does

- Names selection, regression to the mean, nonresponse and common method problems
- Explains why relative importance matters when drivers are correlated
- Designs a comparison group and a second data source such as turnover
- Warns about Campbell's law if scores feed appraisals

Sources

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